

Jeff Geerling

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Mounting an ext4 linux USB drive on macOS in 2024

Jan 24, 2024

I recently pulled a SATA hard drive out of a Linux box that I wanted to grab some files off of. I only had my Mac on hand, and I had a USB 3.0 to SATA hard drive adapter at the ready.

But when I plugged in the hard drive, macOS said it couldn't recognize the disk.



Makes sense, because macOS includes support for Apple's filesystems, not Linux (or even NTFS, Windows' preferred filesystem). There are commercial solutions you can buy, like Paragon Software's [extFS for Mac](#), but that costs \$39, and I don't want to deal with the licensing issues that may exist there if I just want to grab a few files off one hard drive.

Luckily, there are some open source libraries that allow at least *read only* access to ext4-formatted disks on macOS. Let's install them and use them to mount the drive:

First, install [macfuse](#), using [homebrew](#):

```
brew install --cask macfuse
```

This will likely ask you for your sudo password, as it needs to install a kernel extension.

After that's done, you'll need to manually clone and compile ext4fuse:

```
git clone https://github.com/gerard/ext4fuse.git && cd "$(basename "$_" .git)"
make
```

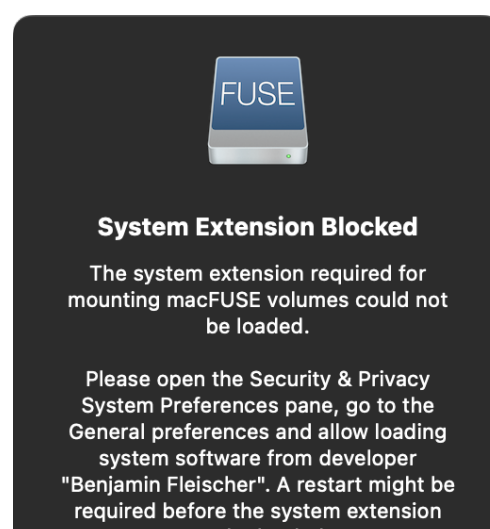
Then create a mount point and mount your external hard drive. If you don't know which drive is the external drive, use `diskutil list` and figure out which one it is—in my case it was `/dev/disk5` (external, physical):

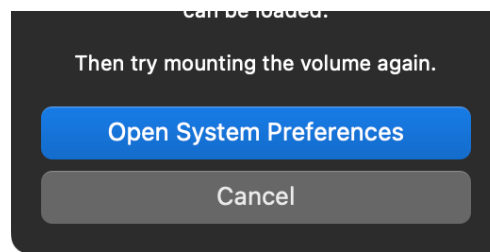
```
$ diskutil list
/dev/disk5 (external, physical):
#  TYPE  NAME      SIZE  IDENTIFIER
0:  GUID_partition_scheme  *20.0 TB  disk5
1:  Microsoft Basic Data  20.0 TB  disk5s1
```

Next, create a mount point for the disk, and then attempt mounting it there:

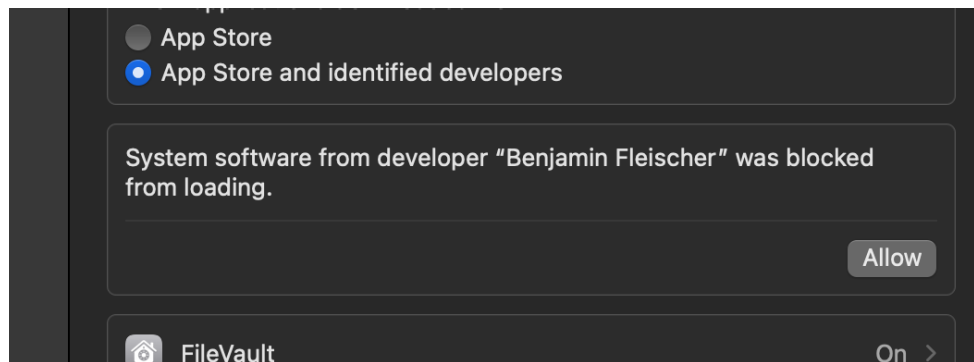
```
mkdir ~/ext4_mount
sudo ./ext4fuse /dev/disk5s1 ~/ext4_mount -o allow_other
```

This will pop a couple warnings like "System Extension Blocked":





Click 'Open System Preferences', then click 'Allow' where it asks if you want to allow the system extension to run:



This will prompt you to reboot the computer — that now, and once you're back up and running, try mounting the disk again:

```
sudo ./ext4fuse /dev/disk5s1 ~/ext4_mount -o allow_other
```

This should work, and you'll see a new disk mounted, like "macFUSE Volume 0 (ext4fuse)". Open that up, and browse around, and you *should* be able to read the contents of the disk now.

When you're finished, run:

```
sudo umount ~/ext4_mount
```

And unmount the disk.

Unfortunately, this doesn't seem to work with *every* partition I've thrown at it. Sometimes it works, sometimes it shows up as an empty volume... not sure why.

The better option would be to have a separate Linux computer (even a little Raspberry Pi!)—plug the drive in there, then if you need the files on your Mac, create a Samba share and access the files over your network.

Further reading:

- [HTGWA: Partition, format, and mount a large disk in Linux with parted](#)
- [Using GPS for the most accurate time possible on a Mac](#)
- [HTGWA: Create a ZFS RAIDZ1 zpool on a Raspberry Pi](#)

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macfly 8/12/2025 at 1:37 AM

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Install anylinuxfs with brew and u good.

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Yacob 8/15/2025 at 4:47 AM ↕

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It doesn't support Intel chip set. Moreover, anylinuxfs can only mount one drive at a time.

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nohajc 4/24/2026 at 9:01 AM ↕

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Update, anylinuxfs can now mount any number of drives at once. Still no Intel support though.

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olvlo 4/16/2026 at 9:46 PM

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Many thanks for the detailed instructions! I'm not sure if this has been mentioned in any other comment, but anylinuxfs (GLI and GUI versions) works very well on my M4 running Tahoe... thought i'd mention it. <https://github.com/nohajc/anylinuxfs>

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Mike Hathaway 11/10/2025 at 9:39 AM

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Geoff Its been a year since you posted this.... It is absolutely fabulous. I needed to mount something and despite many tutorials on the interwebs yours was the only clear simple and complete one available.

[Reply](#)



Jeff Geerling 🟢 11/10/2025 at 9:41 AM ↕

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Heh, in the age of AI slop, I've found that hand-typed guides are still about a zillion times better. So even though Claude, Gemini, Grok, etc. will keep slurping up all my writing and reproducing it, but worse, I will continue writing, even if it's just an audience of one!

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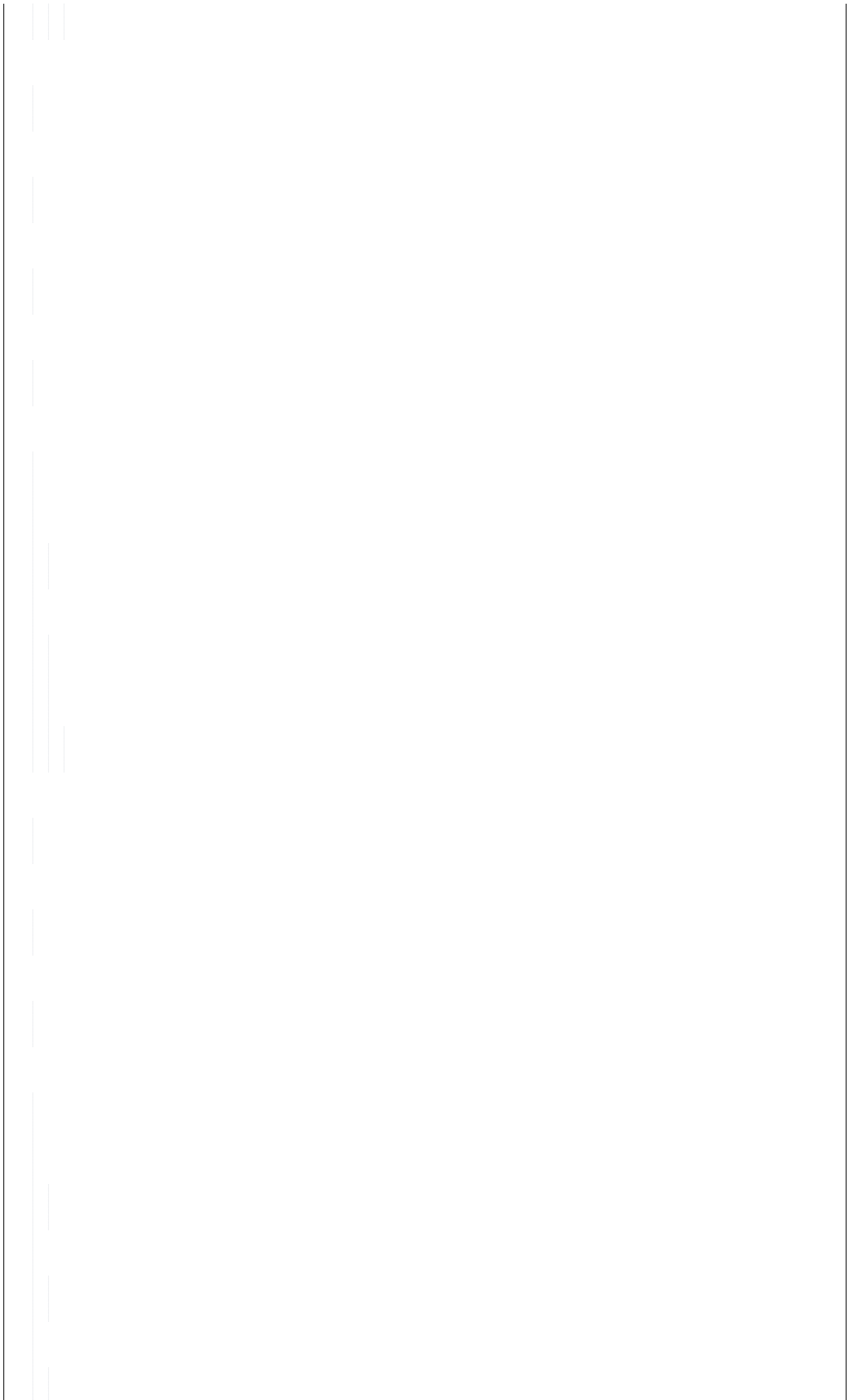


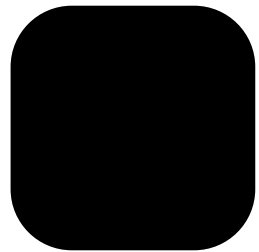
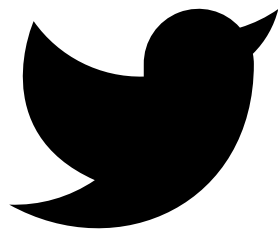
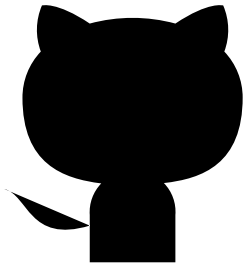
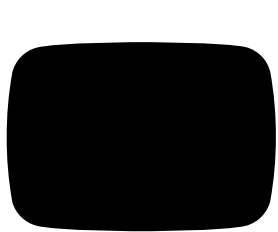
Gonzalo Comas 3/29/2026 at 6:51 PM ↕

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Keep writing, your tutorials are clear and to the point. I wanted to mount an ext4 disc on a Mac and came across this article.

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